

City of New Orleans - rev. 9-16-2026

Writer: Steve Goodman, 1971 / Artist: Arlo Guthrie, 1977

Tempo: 140 / Strum: d- du du du

First Sung Note: G

[C] Riding on the [G] City of New [C] Orleans
[Am] Illinois Central [F] Monday morning [C] rail
[C] Fifteen cars and [G] fifteen restless [C] riders
Three [Am] conductors, and [G] twenty five sacks of [C] mail
All a-[Am] long the south bound odyssey the [Em] train pulls out of Kankakee
[G] Rolls along past houses farms and [D] fields
[Am] Passing trains that have no name [Em] freight yards full of old black men
And the [G] graveyards of [G7] rusted automo-[C] biles

[F] Good morning A-[G]-merica how [C] are you
Say [Am] don't you know me [F] I'm your native [C] son [C] / [G7] / (hold)
I'm the [C] train they call the [G] City of New [Am] Orleans [D7]
I'll be [Gm] gone five [Dm] hundred [G] miles when the day is [C] done

[C] Dealing card games with the [G] old men in the [C] club car
[Am] Penny a point ain't [F] no-one keeping [C] score
[C] Pass the paper [G] bag that holds the [C] bottle
[Am] Feel the wheels [G] rumbling 'neath the [C] floor
And the [Am] sons of Pullman porters and the [Em] sons of engineers
Ride their [G] father's magic carpets made of [D] steel
[Am] Mothers with their babes asleep [Em] rocking to the gentle beat
And the [G] rhythm of the [G7] rails is all they [C] feel

[F] Good morning A-[G]-merica how [C] are you
Say [Am] don't you know me [F] I'm your native [C] son [C] / [G7] / (hold)
I'm the [C] train they call the [G] City of New [Am] Orleans [D7]
I'll be [Gm] gone five [Dm] hundred [G] miles when the day is [C] done

[C] Night time on the [G] City of New [C] Orleans
[Am] Changing cars in [F] Memphis Tenne [C] ssee
[C] Half way home [G] we'll be there by [C] morning
Through the [Am] Mississippi darkness [G] rolling down to the [C] sea
But [Am] all the towns and people seem to [Em] fade into a bad dream
And the [G] steel rail still ain't heard the [D] news
The con-[Am]-ductor sings his songs again
The [Em] passengers will please refrain
This [G] train got the disap-[G7] pearing railroad [C] blues

[F] Good night A-[G] merica how [C] are you
Say [Am] don't you know me [F] I'm your native [C] son [C] / [G7] / (hold)
I'm the [C] train they call the [G] City of New [Am] Orleans [D7]
I'll be [Gm] gone five [Dm] hundred [G] miles when the day is [C] done
I'll be [Gm] gone five [Dm] hundred [G] miles when the day is [C] done [C] // (hold)

